

In the mid-18th century, Swedish botanist and physician Carl Linnaeus revolutionized the way scientists categorized and named living organisms by devising a uniform, hierarchical taxonomic system, which is still in use today.

MILESTONES

HIGHER EDUCATION

Begins studying medicine and botany at Uppsala University in 1728; starts to lecture on botany in 1730.

MAKES EXPEDITION

Travels to Lapland and north Sweden in 1732, and discovers 100 new species of plant.

KEY PUBLICATIONS

Publishes *Systema Naturae* in 1735, securing his reputation; publishes *Genera Plantarum* in 1737.

NEW OCCUPATIONS

Becomes a physician in 1738, then a professor of medicine and botany in 1742.

NAMING SYSTEM

Establishes binomial names for flora in 1753 (*Species Plantarum*) and fauna in 1758 (10th ed. *Systema*).

Linnaeus's favorite plant, *Linnaea borealis* (twinflower), was named after him. Its two-part name indicates its genus and species, a division that Linnaeus himself devised.

Carl Linnaeus was born in a poor area of southern Sweden, where his father was a curate and amateur botanist. While he showed little interest in either his formal education or an ecclesiastical career, his enduring passion and fascination for plants was evident from a young age. After completing his schooling, he studied botany and medicine at Uppsala University and, due to his extensive knowledge of botany, began lecturing at the university 2 years later. In 1732, Linnaeus received funding for a research expedition to Lapland, where he intended to record and gather information on natural resources and discover new species of plants and animals. The results of this expedition were to inspire him to produce a groundbreaking manuscript that would revolutionize the natural sciences.

Categorizing life

The inconsistent and overcomplicated systems of classification that existed at the time frustrated Linnaeus in his botanical studies. Attempts to classify life forms had begun with Aristotle, and while multiple disordered adaptations had appeared over the centuries, by the 18th century, there was still no unified system. During his expeditions in northern Sweden, Linnaeus formulated a method of categorizing different species that would simplify and transform the process.

In 1735, he published the *Systema Naturae*,

